This meant that some deserving candidates were rejected. And one of the victims of this treatment happened to be my son-in-law S Arunan when ISRO selected a team of six scientists in 1993 to visit Russia to study the prospects of cryogenic technology acquisition. A young mechanical engineer with an impeccable track record, Arunan was among the applicants. And I happened to be the member secretary of the selection panel chaired by Muthunayagam.

When Arunan came for the interview, I disclosed my conflict of interest and said I would stay away from the interview of this candidate. The rest of the panel selected Arunan, but Muthunayagam obviously wanted another candidate in his place. After the shortlist was made, Muthunayagam came to me.

'Arunan has been selected on merit,' he said.

'Good,' I said.

'See Nambi, people may say that he was selected because you were part of the selection panel.'

'But I was not part of his selection.'

'That only we know. Others may use this to tarnish your image.'

I laughed.

'I am not bothered about my image since I have not favoured anyone,' I said. Muthunayagam now went to ISRO chairman U R Rao who soon called me. I repeated what I told Muthunayagam.

'I leave the decision to you,' I told Rao. 'But I think it is unfair that someone is denied what he deserves just because he happens to be my son-in-law.'

I don't know what transpired at the ISRO headquarters, but Arunan's name was replaced with that of D P Sudhakar, another fine scientist.

The writing was on the wall: if Arunan continued under Muthunayagam, he would not attain his career trajectory. I advised him to shift out of LPSC. Arunan moved to VSSC under B N Suresh. Three years later, he got a transfer to the ISRO Satellite Applications Centre (ISAC), Bangalore, then headed by Aravamudan. Though a move forced by circumstances, this proved good for Arunan who went on to become the project director of India's first Mars Mission Mangalyaan in 2013.

By now it was crystal clear that be it in recruitment, promotion or just being nice, Muthunayagam had his blatant likes—in fact he appeared to be proud of